

make a profile for yourself. Your profile page allows other users to see what groups you belong to and what discussions you have participated in. Some people don't like this functionality and they can choose to make a limited profile or have their profile completely disabled for view by others.

Groups

Once you have logged in, you can start off by browsing the various groups on the site or by searching for a specific group. We searched for a group for "Electronics Design" and sure enough, we found one (<http://groups.google.com/group/sci.electronics.design>). The groups on the site allow users to interact only in the areas of their interests. Google Groups also searches for usenet groups, which are displayed with a slightly different interface than that of groups on the Google Groups site.

The groups can again be classified under various categories. The owner of the group can classify whether or not anonymous users can post without joining the group. Another functionality unique to Google Groups is that you can choose to have your group opted out of the group categories and searches, thereby making it completely private. When groups allow anonymous users to post, the author's e-mail address is displayed in place of his name. Google Groups scrambles the e-mail address so that it is not "harvested" by e-mail bots and other crawlers on the Net. In order to view a post author's e-mail address, the user has to click onto his name or his scrambled e-mail address after which he is asked to enter the information of a "captcha" image to prove that the user is indeed a human and not a program trying to grab e-mail addresses.

Topics in a group can also be "starred", just like in Gmail. Every post can be rated a maximum of 5 stars and based on its rating, the post moves up in hierarchy in the topic.

Criticism

Google Groups has come under some criticism from its users who state there is not much of a difference to indicate between when